
Weaving Influence: Network Dynamics of U.S. PL-480 Food Aid in Morocco (1957–1965)

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Abstract

The PL-480 program (Public Law 480), officially the Agricultural Trade Development and Assistance Act of 1954, constituted a central instrument of U.S. Cold War foreign aid by converting agricultural surpluses into international food assistance. In Morocco (1957–1965), it functioned not only as a food distribution mechanism but also as a multi-layered governance structure that reorganized institutional relations among U.S. agencies, Moroccan state bodies, and international intermediaries.

The analysis is guided by the following question: how did the PL-480 program in Morocco (1957–1965) operate as a multi-layered governance network through the interaction of food, financial, and technical training flows, and how did these configurations reshape institutional relations over time?

Archival material from the U.S. National Archives and Records Administration (NARA, RG286 and RG59) and the Centre des Archives Diplomatiques de Nantes (CADN) provides the empirical basis, complemented by literature on Cold War aid and development (Lappé, 1971; Schneider, 1978; Hayter, 1971; Trap, 2000; Whitfield, 2009; Bryson, 2012; Cavatorta and Durac, 2011). These sources are used to reconstruct relational ties among actors, focusing on interaction patterns rather than predefined institutional hierarchies.

Social Network Analysis (SNA) and multilayer network modeling structure the methodological approach across three interconnected levels. A global actor network maps relations among U.S., Moroccan, and international institutions (Figure 1). A multiplex structure separates and connects three layers of governance flows—food aid, financial transfers, and technical training—highlighting their interdependence (Figure 2). A temporal analysis traces structural change across three phases (1957–1960, 1961–1963, 1964–1965), capturing shifts in centrality, brokerage, and institutional positioning (Figure 3).

The network structure does not present a stable hierarchical center. Governance is instead organized through dynamic multi-centrality. Over time, USAID becomes increasingly central as a brokerage node, reflected in rising betweenness centrality, linking Moroccan institutions, international organizations, and intermediary actors. This shift corresponds to a structural transformation from a food distribution regime into an integrated governance system combining material aid, financial mediation, and technical capacity-building.

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Food, financial, and training flows operate as structurally coupled mechanisms rather than separate domains. Their interaction produces asymmetric relational positions in which Moroccan institutions function as intermediary nodes embedded within dependency relations. Across the observed phases, increasing network density and interconnection reinforce coordination through relational mechanisms rather than hierarchical control (Figures 2 and 3).

Cold War dynamics are embedded within the internal organization of the network rather than acting as an external context. PL-480 operates as a relational governance system in which power emerges through brokerage positions and dependency structures rather than direct bilateral control. This perspective reframes development aid as a distributed networked system in which influence is produced through relational configurations.

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Keywords: PL, 480, Food Aid, Social Network Analysis, Cold War, Morocco, Multilayer Networks, Governance Networks, Archival Sources

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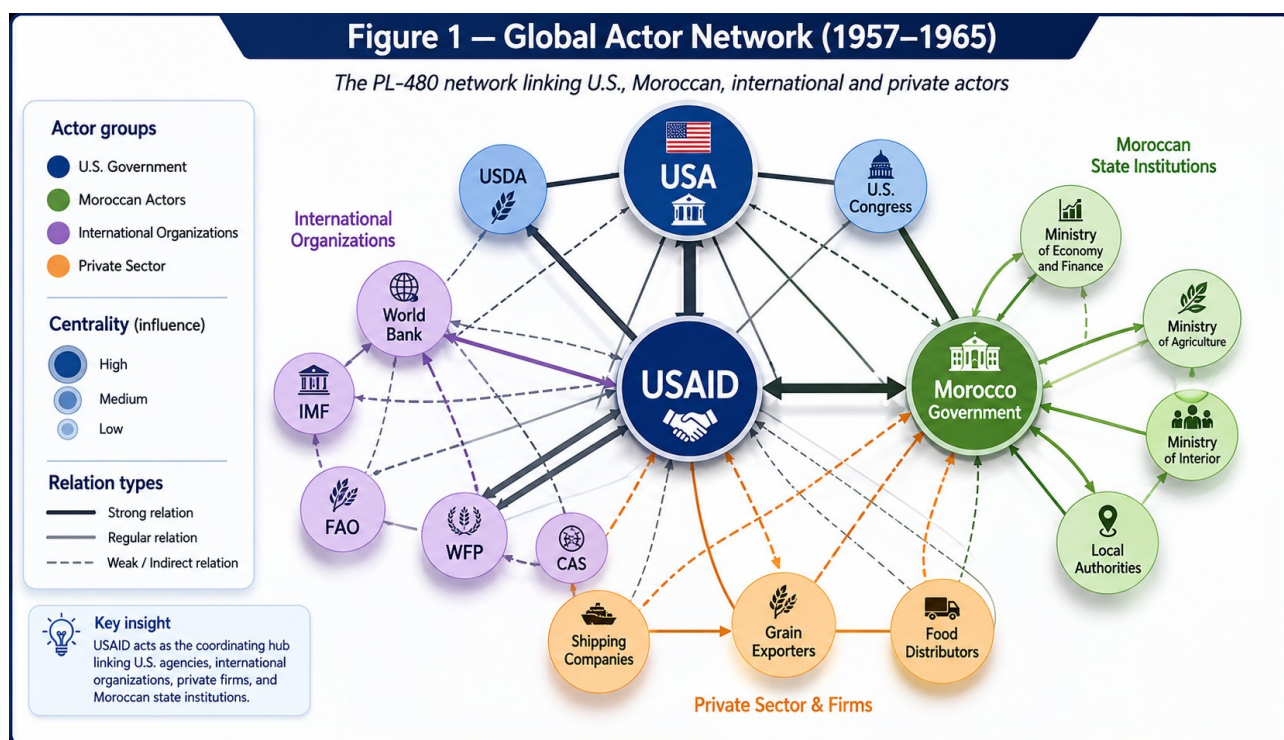


Figure 1. Global actor network showing relations among U.S., Moroccan, and international institutions.

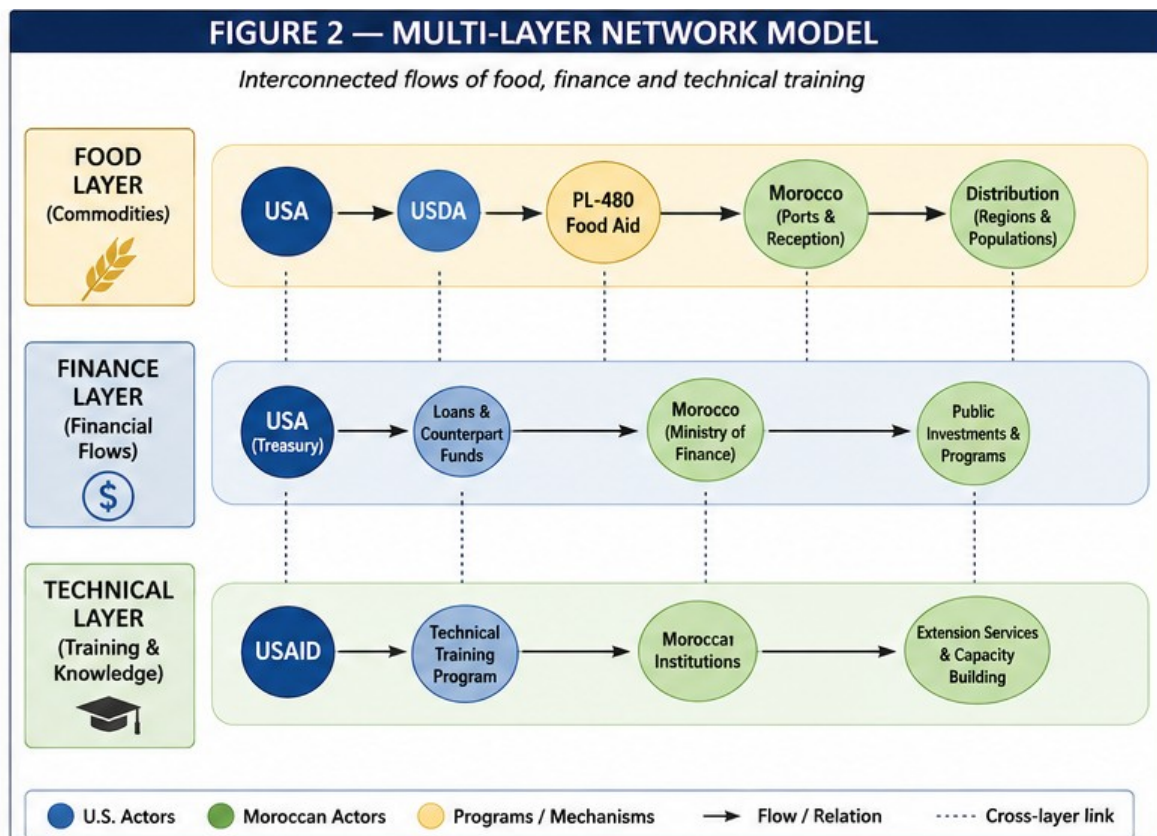


Figure 2. Multiplex network showing three layers of governance flows: food aid, financial transfers, and technical training.

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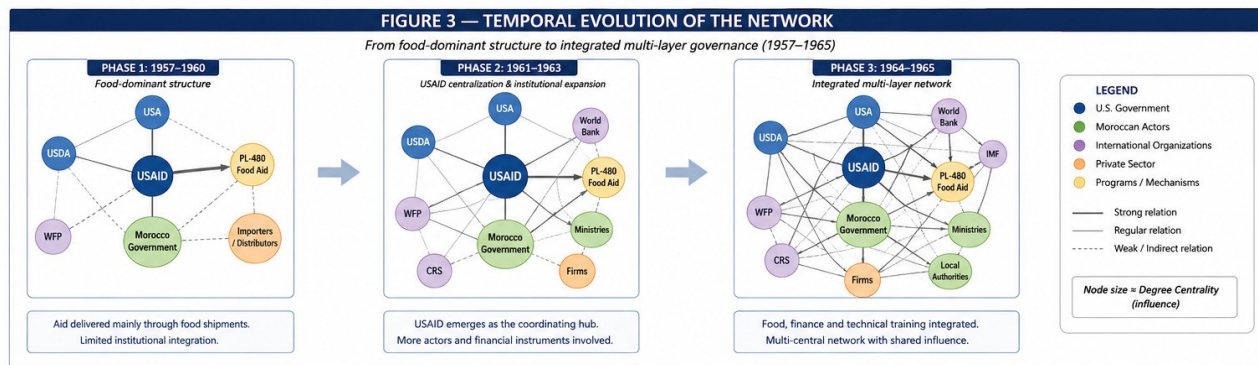


Figure 3. Temporal network evolution across three phases (1957–1960, 1961–1963, 1964–1965), highlighting changes in centrality and brokerage roles.